

Garden cities

In 1898, British reformer Ebenezer Howard (1850–1928) described a utopian city where citizens would live in harmony with nature (illustrated opposite). Out of this emerged the garden city movement: a method of urban planning that focused on organizing new towns, surrounded by countryside, that would give the working classes a healthy alternative to overcrowded inner cities. Howard's vision was for people to live in concentrically planned towns, with boulevards radiating from the centre, parks and open spaces interspersing built areas, and a generous garden for every dwelling. Once each city filled (to a maximum of 32,000 people), another would be built, leading to clusters throughout the country, linked by road and rail. With its roots in the Arts and Crafts movement, the garden city ideal incorporated all that a community would need. During 1903–07, Letchworth Garden City was built in Hertfordshire, followed by Welwyn Garden City, approximately 19 kilometres (12 miles) away, in 1920. The idea was influential in the United States, leading to the creation of cities such as Sunnyside in Queens (1924–8).

